

SELF IN RELATIONSHIP

AN INTRODUCTION TO IFS COUPLE

THERAPY

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INTRODUCTION

Almost immediately after meeting Elizabeth and her husband Mark it was clear to me that they were at an impasse. “We feel terrible,” Elizabeth said. “We know we love each other but we fight all the time, we can’t talk to each other anymore.

“We disagree about everything,” Mark said.

These kinds of statements are common at the beginning of couple therapy. After trying to fix what they believe is wrong with their relationship, many couples enter therapy feeling discouraged, isolated and hopeless. Internal family systems therapy (IFS) invites people first to learn how to be in a loving relationship with themselves and, from that state, to attempt a heartfelt connection with their intimate partner. We offer the concept of parts and Self to help couples reframe their bitter struggles and understand relationships differently. It is my belief that working with parts and accessing Self-energy are the keys to positive change and growth.

This chapter illustrates the theory and concepts of IFS in action in couple therapy, highlighting key interventions with case examples. The reader will learn how the IFS therapist sets the stage immediately for the differentiation of parts from Self, which in turn helps individuals to regulate intense emotion, heal from toxic shame and communicate skillfully.

A FIRST SESSION: LAYING THE GROUNDWORK

As I continued to interview Mark and Elizabeth, I invited them to talk more about what brought them to therapy. To gauge their level of comfort with themselves, I watched their body language closely. I noticed that Mark looked to Elizabeth for affirmation. With a sideways glance at his wife, he seemed to say, “I cannot be OK if you don’t think I’m OK. If my experience of me is different from your experience of me, I feel insecure.”

What he actually said to me was, “When Elizabeth and I decided to get married we were always on the same page, we didn’t disagree about anything. But then we began to fight about the stupidest things. I feel like she’s changed. I don’t get it.”

“And how do you understand all of this disagreeing after you got married?”

“In a disagreement, someone has to be right and someone has to be wrong. Turns out I’m always wrong.” Mark said.

“Not true!” Elizabeth responded angrily. “It’s you who always has to be right or you stop engaging.” She went on to describe a damaging pattern of coping. First each tried to enroll the other to think and feel the same way about things. When this failed, Mark would capitulate and deny his experience to recover the illusion of sameness with Elizabeth. But when his sacrifice failed to help them recover the desired sameness of thinking and feeling, they both grew disappointed and angry. In anger they would retreat into *being right*, discounting each other’s perspective.

“What,” I asked, “do you hope for in couple therapy?”

“We’d like to get back on track,” Mark said.

“What would that look like?” I asked.

“Where we see things the same way and can agree again,” Elizabeth said.

“What is the most important thing about agreeing?” I asked.

“Peace! No conflict,” Mark said.

“Can I ask what you both learned about conflict in relationships when you were young?”

Rather than getting caught in the content of their arguments, I stepped back internally to notice their patterns of interacting, paying close attention to how they were communicating with me and with each other. Observing for myself at this point rather than out loud, I watched how they turned away from each other and spoke to me as though the other person was not in the room. Mark was quick to defend himself by saying things such as, “If you wouldn’t have done this or that, I wouldn’t have reacted as I did.” In response Elizabeth fell into stony silence.

As with many couples seeking help they could not at this point stay open and curious. They alternated between angry, defensive hyperaroused parts, and withdrawn, collapsed hypo-aroused parts who made them inarticulate. This told me that they could not yet separate, or *unblend*, from reactive protectors.

In most couples protectors vie for power and influence in the relational system. In my experience, the protectors of one person will try to convince me that their partner is the real reason for their

relational conflict by making provocative statements like, “He’s so out of touch with his feelings. He watches TV all the time at night and has no interest in communicating.” Although I take note of this information, I am very careful not to get lost in a fog of content or be seduced by a critical manager. Rather my first task is to help them understand the behavior and motivation of their protectors in these cycles of reactivity.

“All the concerns and feelings you have make sense to me,” I said to Mark and Elizabeth. “I understand that it feels awful between you and has for awhile. It sounds to me as though you haven’t been able to stay connected in the way that used to feel so good.”

As I continued to validate and normalize their experience, I noticed their bodies relaxing. Mark leaned back; Elizabeth took a deep breath. They looked at each other kindly and nodded at me. I asked them, “What would life be like if you experienced less internal reactivity toward each other and at the same time could listen to each other’s perspectives with curiosity and without having to agree?”

“This is what we want!” they agreed. “We all have parts,” I said, explaining how, in the view of IFS, protectors in one person will trip protectors in the other. I went on to illustrate how protectors serve vulnerable parts, and how the self-protective impulses we all share create these very typical cycles of painful interaction.

Then I explained that in IFS therapy we invite couples to embrace what [Schwartz \(2008\)](#) describes as a *U-turn*. This signifies a process that involves asking an individual to discontinue their outward focus on the other person. We invite them to turn back toward themselves, to their own inner experience. The U-turn is a client’s first step toward internal differentiation. It is an invitation to form compassionate relationships with wounded parts and end the tidal pull of past trauma on the present. We then invite them to re-“turn” to their partner in a different state of mind; more present, more attuned. It can be a stretch, especially at the beginning of therapy, for people in pain to believe that they can change from the inside out and that doing so will change their experience from the outside in.

“Your most protective parts,” I said to Mark and Elizabeth, “may balk at the idea of moving inside to be curious about yourself instead of focusing on changing each other. But my experience—and I have a lot of it—says this will change your relationship and empower you to feel better. Right now, it will probably be a leap of faith.”

GOALS OF IFS COUPLE THERAPY

The word *differentiation* can be construed in a number of ways. When I use it, I mean being in relationship with another while maintaining connection with and regulating one’s own internal experience. This is a particular challenge in times of stress. The level of differentiation between partners is a reflection of the level of differentiation inside each individual. External reactivity stems from internal reactivity, from conflict between parts in a state of disconnection from Self. To assess internal differentiation I look not only at relationships in the client’s internal system, but also at how the client responds in external relationships. Protective adaptations such as avoidance or enmeshment at either level can block healthy differentiation. My goal for couples is attuned and loving relationships inside

and out. In this state partners realize they are capable of taking care of their injured parts and they interact from Self-leadership for the sake of the relationship (Schwartz, 2008). Even though the external relational field is our first point of contact with a couple, in IFS couple therapy we prioritize the internal. Our initial aim, which I illustrate in the cases that follow, is to help parts differentiate from the Self to recognize and re-attach to the Self. This internal attachment work paves the relational road of the couple.

We work with the internal system much as we would work with an external system, learning about the roles and protective functions of parts, supporting the development of relationships between parts, and between parts and Self, and then helping our clients to access vulnerable young parts who carry the burdens of relational trauma. As the internal system shifts we can usually observe positive effects on external relationships as well. In brief, we see the external mirroring the internal. We always keep in mind that the painful polarizations, fears, conflict, rage and withdrawal that we see between partners are also occurring internally between the parts of each client.

The art of couple work in IFS lies in balancing in-depth individual IFS work with a focus on the relationship. This entails a variety of strategies: asking one person to go inside while supporting the other one to remain engaged and present; then moving back to external relational work and teaching the couple to speak for parts, listen from Self and try on new ways of behaving that foster differentiation, individuality and connection. This changes old patterns of relating and moves couples forward.

SELF AND AFFECT REGULATION

Although self-defense in the face of interpersonal provocation is hard to resist, in IFS couple therapy we invite both listener and speaker to have curiosity about him- or herself before responding. The ability to be with one's own feelings regardless of intense physiological arousal is key. For example, when a partner gives painful feedback or expresses anger directly from, rather than for, an agitated protector, the therapist might make the following intervention, as I did with my client, Adam, during an interaction with his wife, Erin.

“Adam, I’d like to take a moment and slow you down. May I help you talk to Erin in a way that she just might be able to hear you?”

Adam took a breath and sat back. I waited a moment and then asked, “What’s happening in your body right now?”

“I feel tense,” Adam replied.

“Where, in or around your body, do you feel the tension?”

“Some in my shoulders but mostly in my gut,” he said.

“Would you focus on your gut for a minute?” I asked.

“OK.”

“As you focus there,” I said, “what do you hear yourself saying to yourself?”

“Let her have it!”

“What’s the feeling that goes with those words?” I asked.

“I’m angry,” he replied, “and I want to let her have it!”

“Would you be willing to stay focused on that anger and the impulse to let Erin have it?”

“I don’t like to focus on my anger,” Adam said.

“Tell me more.”

“I’m not an angry person. But Erin is so busy not listening to me that I can’t help being angry.”

“Adam, I’m sure it’s true you’re not always angry. But just for today, would you consider that this anger is coming from a part of you and is not all of you?”

Adam took a moment. “OK,” he finally said.

“Would you consider that for today there is an angry part in your gut?”

“I guess I can be curious,” he said.

“Great. And would it be OK to keep focusing on it, just for a little while longer?”

“I can feel it,” he said.

“How do you feel toward it?”

“Well, I don’t love it if that’s what you’re asking.”

“It’s fine not to love it. Given that you don’t love it, how do you feel toward it?”

“OK, I guess.”

I said, “As strange as this might seem, Adam, let’s ask this part of you what it hopes for? What does it want for you right now?” Adam paused for a few seconds, crossing his arms and looking down. Softly, I inquired, “What are you noticing?”

“Maybe I can get her attention and she will know what I’m feeling.”

“So the hope of this part is that if you get angry enough, Erin just might pay attention to how you feel?”

“Yes, and maybe she will *feel* what I feel as well.”

“Does it make sense that you have a part trying really hard to get Erin’s attention?”

Adam took a breath “Yes it does. I never took the time to see it from this perspective before.”

“How does it feel to do that now?”

“I can feel myself relaxing.”

“Great,” I said. “When the time feels right, would you speak for the angry part about whether this strategy for trying to get Erin’s attention is working? Is it getting Erin’s attention?”

“Not in a good way,” Adam said.

“Let’s ask it if there was another way to get Erin’s attention without having to take you over like this, would it be interested?”

Adam paused and closed his eyes momentarily. Then he said, “Yes, I think it is interested.”

“And how is your gut?”

“Relaxed.”

This interaction with Adam is an example of how internal differentiation can regulate arousal. Supported by the calm, nonjudgmental presence of the therapist, Adam connected with a distressed inner part and, as that part gradually separated from him, he relaxed. In this way, Adam moved from a dysregulated state to a more optimal state of regulation in which he felt attuned to rather than overwhelmed by his body and emotions. Now he was prepared to talk with Erin.

THE THERAPIST AND SELF-REGULATION

IFS therapy holds that therapists also have exiled parts in pain and protective parts in conflict (Schwartz, this volume). Success in treating couples depends on the therapist knowing her own system. IFS couple therapists will inevitably run into many of their own parts who fear conflict or have strong views on infidelity, caretaking and all the other issues that typically arise for couples. The gift for the therapist in the practice of IFS couple therapy lies in discovering that she is in the same process as her clients with the same rich, exciting inner life.

As the IFS therapist learns to work with her system in the same way as her clients she gains the ability to access Self-energy and regulate her feelings when triggered by the parts of the couple. And, although the locus of healing in IFS is not dependent on the therapist's insight, being insightful, wise and able to speak for one's own parts can create safety and trust in the consultation room.

LEARNING TO COMMUNICATE WELL

Internal differentiation, one of the first goals of IFS couple therapy, begins with attention to parts and their relationship with the Self. However, clinicians should note that learning to unblend from parts and maintain emotional self-regulation can feel disempowering for clients for a number of reasons. First, it often takes couples years to seek treatment once they have identified the need for help, so their patterns are entrenched and protectors can feel that maintaining the status quo is a matter of survival. Second, their protectors are experiencing intense feelings and impulses. And, third, although exploding perpetuates vicious patterns, allowing a reactive part to take over in front of the therapist can be a relief, like taking the top off a pressure cooker. And when one partner is threatening, asking the other (who may already feel critical toward him or herself) to extend compassion is nearly impossible. Even if one partner can do it with my help in my office, the couple will often reengage and reinjure each other on the way to the car. From an IFS perspective we view this type of external reactivity as stemming from internal reactivity, from conflict between parts in a state of disconnection from Self. It takes courage—and encouragement—for couples to agree to try out this perspective and slow down their process.

Alison and Steve had a 3-year-old and 5-year-old twins. The stress of having three young children was enormous and both were angry. More often than not they communicated through protectors who blamed, shamed and countershamed using phrases such as *you always ... you never ... if only you would stop ... if only you would be different. ...* Highly reactive couples such as this are usually concerned when I ask them to look for answers within because it sounds as if I am asking them to remain isolated with their emotional pain.

"I have to have more help. I'm in this relationship alone, doing all the work! What am I supposed to do?" Alison asked.

"Of course," I replied, "getting your needs met and feeling that your partner is there for you is key." Because helping couples separate from their parts and feel Self-energy is crucial, I repeatedly direct

them back to noticing their own experience, as I did now with Alison. “Asking to have your needs met is no problem, but how you ask may be,” I went on. “Are you speaking for a part or from a part when you make requests? And if you’re speaking from a part, is it working?”

Alison said, “Maybe I’m not doing a very good job of it but I don’t think Steve is capable of meeting my needs anyway.”

“Alison,” I replied, “do you notice what’s happening in your body as you speak now?”

“I’m shut down, just shut down!” she exclaimed angrily. “I don’t know, maybe I should leave. Just leave!” She glared at her husband.

A couple will accept a therapist as a competent guide once they experience her presence as empathic and nonjudgmental during their most difficult interactions. I became aware of a part of me who was reacting to her as I had to my own mother when I was a child. This part wanted Alison to calm down and see things from Steve’s perspective just as I had longed for my mother to do when she was arguing with my father. As the IFS therapist helps clients shift toward inner awareness, she also continually asks her own parts to step aside or soften to allow ongoing access to Self-energy. I recognized my countertransference and gently asked my own young part to move out of the crossfire so I could remain present with Alison’s distress.

“Alison,” I said, “please look at me for a moment. I believe that you have something important to say to Steve. And I feel pretty sure if the part of you who is so angry continues to speak to him in this way, his protective parts will have no choice but to take care of him and chances are he won’t be able to respond in the way you wish he would.”

“I know,” she began to cry. “I’m so angry! So angry!”

“Your need for help, for connection, and your wish for a partner are all healthy impulses,” I said. Alison continued to cry. “What’s happening?” I asked.

“I wish I wasn’t so screwed up. I’m always the problem.”

“You have a part who feels she’s always the problem?” I asked.

“Yes, I’m always the emotional one and Steve has me in a box that he won’t let me out of.”

“I hear you. I hear this part feels like a problem. I would like to know more about that.”

Alison closed her eyes. “I feel so much shame.”

“Can you stay with that feeling?” I asked. Alison nodded. “Would you be willing to explore the part who feels ashamed?”

“Yes,” she said.

“Good. Alison, I want you to be heard and I want Steve to be able to listen to you. And I want to help you know that you can take yourself out of that box. Will you give me some time to help you do this differently?”

“I really want things to be different.”

At this moment, I turned to Steve. “I would like to stay with Alison for a little while right now and help her understand what’s happening inside. How would it feel if together you and I remained a little bit curious with her?”

“That’s fine,” he responded.

“If it gets tough to listen or you are uncomfortable, it would be great if you let me know,” I said.

“I appreciate that,” he replied. “I’ll flag you down if this gets too hard.”

Before helping Alison communicate differently with Steve, I invited her to understand the source of her anger and alleviate some of her shame response by unburdening an exile who felt worthless. After she understood the relationship between her angry protector and this shamed exile, I began the process of inviting the couple to learn a method of communication that we call *speaking for parts and listening from Self*.

You have probably had the opportunity in your life to notice how difficult it is to communicate clearly when a part of you is enraged or terrified. In IFS we teach couples to help their parts differentiate enough so that the couple can speak *for* their parts and from Self, instead of *from* their parts in a state of intense reactivity. In other words, we help them to speak on behalf of their extreme feelings. But this process, called *unblending*, requires the cooperation of parts. Getting their cooperation requires the therapist to be patient and to cultivate the courage of protective parts: courage to believe that good things will happen when the protector allows the Self to be a resource during difficult communications and courage to relax and wait while listening to a partner during conflict. All this grows experientially, step by step.

With Alison and Steve, I began by making a contract to be their *parts detector*. In service of maintaining safety, I said, “I will not allow you to harm each other and I am asking for an agreement from you both that will permit me to intervene should protectors begin to take over.”

Allowing a protector to take over (or, in IFS terms, *blend*) and then attack can feel good, relieving and powerful in the short run. But when protectors repeat this type of behavior expecting to produce change in the other person, they inevitably get back exactly what they hope to avoid. I wanted Steve to experience listening without having to defend. I turned to him, “Are you available to listen while Alison speaks on behalf of what is going on inside of her right now?”

“I’ll try,” Steve said.

“In my experience listening can be difficult,” I said. “Will you check to see if you have parts who might interfere with you listening to Alison?”

Once Steve was able to acknowledge and unblend from parts who might have had trouble listening, I turned to Alison with a similar invitation. “Before you begin speaking to Steve, let me ask you to check inside just as I asked Steve. Can you ask your parts to trust you to speak on their behalf?”

“I can do that,” she said. “I have more space inside.” At this, Steve reached out and touched Alison’s shoulder and they looked each other in the eye. Alison said to him, “I can speak about what’s going on in me without attacking you.”

When a couple achieves this point of differentiation from protectors and there are moments of Self-led interaction, the therapist can enjoy a moment of quiet, holding Self-energy for the couple who are now guiding their own conversation. It may only last for minutes or seconds but as they achieve untroubled moments they begin to appreciate once again their bond and their friendship. Neuroscience now confirms that repeating newly generated responses changes neuronal pathways in the brain along with old patterns of thinking and behaving (Lind-Kyle, 2009). When we are able to listen with all our senses, hear accurately what is being said, stay in the present and respond with empathy, we are successful in what Siegel (2003) called a contingent, attuned communication, which is self-reinforcing. These moments of heart-felt connection in session are essential to regulating chronic viciousness.

Helping couples learn to communicate well may take a long time and unburdening exiles of their extreme beliefs is key to success. In my experience, effective communication in which partners speak for parts and listen from Self takes the fear out of discussing difficult issues. Also in my experience, protectors balk at practicing communication skills because close, mindful attention to intention and speech takes them out of the driver's seat. Nevertheless, I explain to the couple that if they are willing to practice this as any other skill, their protectors will gain trust and their conversations will become easier. When I work with a couple, I encourage this style of communication, particularly in my office, until controlled practice becomes skilled interaction that is natural and intuitive.

Steve and Alison both noticed that when she *unblended* from her frustrated part and found the need hidden deep below it, Steve's protectors dropped their defenses and he became more available. However, when Alison's protectors took over, yelling and cursing, his autonomic nervous system shifted into fight or flight, a state of hyperarousal in which his heartbeat sped up, his muscles contracted and, though he had not actually done it, he felt the urge to get up and run. With his protectors yelling at him to get away from her, Steve needed help to stay present and listen. In sessions when Steve was asked to listen to Alison *speak for* her frustrated parts, I invited him to stay present to the sensations in his body so that he could understand his inner responses. And I worked with him on accessing Self-energy to soothe his system as he listened. Little by little Alison and Steve started to use the IFS way of communicating, speaking for parts and listening from Self, without coaching. Doing this fundamentally changed their ability to have important and necessary conversations, a key goal of IFS couple therapy. Their successes in my office began to translate to interactions at home. The impulse to withdraw slowly shifted toward an impulse to reach out and stay present.

"I can listen to Alison without interrupting," Steve reported. "My need to defend myself all the time has really shifted. And I'm learning to think about my responses to her without qualifying my answers with a story."

Alison added, "I can listen without interrupting, too. And I don't lead with my angry parts. The thing I like best is asking for my needs to be met clearly and honestly."

This case exemplifies how difficult it can be for couples with impulsive protectors to communicate artfully. Once these parts learn to trust the Self of each individual, they can speak and listen without tumbling into childhood memories that evoke vicious protective responses. Over time, the couple accesses a critical mass of Self-energy so they can trust themselves and each other without having to withdraw or attack.

INTERRUPTING SHAME AND BLAME

"She's so critical of me," John said about his partner, Sharon, with palpable disdain.

"Here it is," I thought, "a classic case of spinning pinwheels." *Spinning pinwheels* is a phrase [Schwartz \(2008\)](#) coined to describe how internal interactions between unacknowledged parts get projected into the relational dynamic of a couple. At the beginning of this therapy my client was able to identify his partner's critical part but not his own.

“What happens inside when you experience her criticism?” I asked to elicit his curiosity.

“I feel hostile,” he said, “wouldn’t you?”

“Let’s stay with the part of you who feels hostile,” I said.

“How?” he asked.

“Where do you experience the hostile feelings physically?” I asked.

“In my arms and hands.”

“Without wishing it away, would you ask the part in your arms and hands to give you space by separating from you just a little bit?” John nodded. “As you focus on it,” I continued, “how do you feel toward it?”

“I’m all right with it. It feels like armor.”

“Does that make sense to you?”

“Yes it does. It feels like it has to defend itself ... to defend me!”

And so I began the journey of helping John turn inward, encouraging him to notice his own experience. John discovered that his angry part was protecting a younger part who had suffered day in and day out at the hands of a critical father. This young boy felt he was a failure in his father’s eyes. My goal was to help John understand that his internal critic maintained a vigilant internal watch on this boy to keep him from making mistakes and feeling like a failure in John’s current life. His wife’s dissatisfactions evoked self-criticism and initiated a miserable internal cycle of blame and shame. Each time we experience shame we go back in time to related experiences and to all the ways in which we attempted to soothe ourselves to feel better. As Nathanson (1992) wrote, human beings will avoid feelings of humiliation at all costs and in a number of ways. John’s immediate impulse when he felt criticized was to withdraw, attack himself and then attack his wife. That is, in the blink of an eye his inner critic turned on the young boy inside and then, protecting that injured boy, a rageful part turned on his partner.

“In the hope of what?” I asked.

“I make her feel how she makes me feel.”

“And then what?” I asked.

“She stops criticizing me,” he said.

“And then what,” I asked again gently.

“We aren’t fighting anymore,” he said. “And I don’t have to keep feeling like an asshole who can never get anything right!”

In couple therapy we often see partners whose protectors have become polarized due to shame and humiliation. According to many protectors, the solution to feeling shame is to blame. However the true antidote to shame is self-compassion, which has the additional benefit of helping people take responsibility for their own behaviors and actions (Neff, 2011; Sweezy, this volume). The IFS therapist guides clients to call shamed parts out of the dark and into connection with compassionate inner witnessing while at the same time helping the shaming parts to feel understood so they can retire. This method is an internal correction to the isolation and loneliness that accompany shame (Bradshaw, 1988; Neff, 2011).

We can view the behavior of protective parts like John’s as their best guess about how to gain control and be safe, and we know that this guess occurs too quickly for conscious awareness.

Neuroscience tells us that it takes much longer for the cortex to process an emotionally dangerous situation than it does for the amygdala, the core circuitry for fear and attachment, to shift into gear. Therefore although “we are under the illusion that we are making conscious, adult decisions based on present day circumstances ... by the time we are consciously aware of an experience, it’s been processed and re-processed in the brain’s primitive regions, activating old memory” (Cozolino, 2008, p. 24).

In other words, though we tend to believe we are operating rationally in the present, current emotional responses are actually governed by past experience. Couples in IFS learn that feelings, though valid, are not necessarily accurate barometers of a present interaction, much less of another person’s intention. In John’s case, childhood experiences of being shamed had motivated protectors to hide his desire for connection. With the hope of getting John’s tender needs met, his angry protector demanded that his wife be kind and gentle—and their relationship suffered accordingly. As John developed a relationship with his critic, he came to understand this protective intent. In turn, the critic calmed down and John was able to move closer to the parts who had been chronically shamed by his father. Externally, this shift in John helped Sharon to relax and be curious about her own responses. They both reported feeling more spacious inside and their conversations shifted from bullying and defensiveness to, *let me see if I can really hear what you are saying*, a practice that allowed them to give and receive feedback about their own feelings without wounding each other over and over again.

As we saw with John, exiled parts—the objects of all this protection—are the ones who have taken direct hits in traumatic situations, often early in childhood with caretakers and attachment figures. Children imbibe felt meaning from these events and then go on telling themselves stories about themselves based on that meaning. I call these beliefs *relational burdens*. A relational burden of shame goes something like this, *I am unlovable, I am not good enough, I am bad, or I am worthless*. As long as shame rekindles internally and our protectors lead our relationships, love cannot counteract this early injury.

Once John and Sharon began experimenting with saying *yes* and *no* to requests from each other with more clarity, they found courage to speak truths with care and respect and to hear feedback without rigid protection. For example, they reported to me that after a miscommunication in between sessions Sharon caught herself speaking from a critical part. She asked John if he would let her begin again, which he did. While expressing her frustration, she made her request by speaking from Self. John reported, “I felt that young boy inside but it was a blip instead of a nuclear blast. I appreciated Sharon catching herself, so instead of melting down I listened. And it wasn’t such a big deal.”

Our goal in IFS couple therapy is for individuals to develop the loving and attuned relationships with their own inner children that they have always longed for. As this begins to integrate internally, it becomes easier and easier to interrupt the impulse of a protector and respond differently regardless of what a partner is doing or saying.

THE RISK OF CHANGE

All therapists know clients who hold fast to the comfort of the familiar. Any risk of being different or attempting the unknown can evoke fears of failure, disconnection and rejection. I believe it is important to offer couples hope that change is possible while respecting fear about the risks of letting go. John spoke again, “We’ve experienced some shifts in our relating but change is a bit risky.”

“I’d like to hear more about that,” I said.

“Don’t know much more,” he said, “and I’m not even sure how to know the specifics. I just know it seems scary and risky.”

“Is there a part of you who worries about what might happen, John, if you take risks to understand yourself and then you change the way you relate to your wife?” I asked.

“What if she doesn’t like the change after all?” he said.

When a therapist asks clients to take a relational risk by doing something different or invites him to ponder the possibility that something wonderful could happen from witnessing the past, resistance from his protectors is predictable and makes sense. For both partners, I suggest small, manageable changes at home and we also do experiments in the office. For example, I may ask a partner to change a behavior and doing it from Self rather than an angry protector or following an impulse to make a move in the other’s direction literally or metaphorically. I invite couples to try on new behaviors designed to help them engage in right-brain-to-right-brain interactions, such as sharing vulnerability, maintaining eye contact for mere seconds or staying connected in a virtuous cycle of appreciation followed by loving touch. These experiences rewire patterns of security (Badenoch, 2008; Siegel, 2007) and will eventually lead to more permanent changes in thinking and behaving.

YOU ARE NOT IN THIS ALONE: GETTING NEEDS MET

“I don’t want to be responsible for taking care of Karen’s needy demands,” Joan exclaimed.

When Joan’s partner, Karen, approached her with vulnerability, Joan had parts who felt responsible to take care of all Karen’s needs. This belief evoked terror and anger in other parts. Because of this internal polarity, Joan withdrew from Karen’s bid for connection and was not open to Karen’s young parts. Joan’s protectors were unable to discern the difference between *care taking* and *being caring*. The former is laden with responsibility while the latter is a natural state of Self-leadership.

“What if,” I asked Joan, “your current response to feeling burdened with responsibility was not your only option? Or what if you didn’t even have to feel burdened?”

“Interesting but not possible,” Joan replied.

Karen, in turn said, “If I can’t get my needs met, why am I in this relationship to begin with?”

Karen also had an internal polarity. Hers was between protectors who were in the habit of pursuing external security, pleading and demanding on behalf of exiles who longed to be taken care of exclusively by Joan, and protectors who became critical, demanding and shaming of Joan when she did not meet these needs.

This dynamic speaks to an issue that arises in most relationships: Who takes care of whom? Whose needs take precedence? Schwartz (2008), articulating the pivotal goals of IFS couple therapy, wrote that each person in the couple will retrieve projections, cease blaming, practice self-compassion and generally become the primary caretaker for their own young parts. This U-turn (Schwartz, 2008) brings Self-energy to exiles and allows a partner to achieve success as a secondary source of love and support.

Because vulnerable young parts can flood the internal system with terrifying emotion, IFS couple therapy, just as individual therapy, must attend to the extreme beliefs of exiles. As exiles surface, some couples need individual sessions. However, many can create enough safety to do a U-turn and attend to exiles in the presence of a partner. Because we all have exiles, IFS teaches therapists—and we invite couples—to embrace the U-turn. The goal of a U-turn is not to stay focused inward but to re-turn to the other, empowered by Self-energy. Partners learn to receive the care that is offered while remaining present to themselves and being their own source of constancy when that love is not available. And when partners are no longer called on to meet all needs, they are free to notice the true profound significance of their love and support. These points are well illustrated in the case below.

After acknowledging that Joan and Karen believed their dynamic could never improve, I said, “How might you respond to each other if you were not so angry or terrified?”

“How?” Joan asked.

“The part of you who’s terrified of Karen’s needs must have a story to tell. Could you be curious enough to listen to what it has to tell you?”

“I guess so,” Joan said.

“Think of a time recently when Karen asked you for something and you couldn’t help but react negatively,” I said.

“That’s easy,” Joan said. “Can you feel what happens in your body?” I asked. “I sure can. It feels like an incredible impulse to push her away.”

“Focus on that impulse. How do you feel toward the part who wants to push away?”

“I’m so used to it, so tired of it! It happens so fast, I feel like I don’t have control over it.”

“Let’s ask the part who feels tired of it to back away so you can stay present and focus on it.”

“It’s like it wants to get me away, out of the room.”

“Away from what?” I asked.

After a moment or two of silence Joan responded, “The burden of having to be a parent way too soon, while I was still a child.”

As Joan listened to her panicked and repulsed parts, they took her back to early experiences of being used by, and responsible for, her alcoholic mother. Joan’s past was dictating her response to Karen in the present. Parts who are activated in the storehouse of past experience have no notion of present time. But even as Joan explored her traumatic childhood experience, I knew I could not for one minute minimize Karen’s inquiry about getting her needs met. Why be in a relationship where your emotional needs are never met? “Human beings are hardwired for connection and naturally long for love and security,” I said

to Karen. “There is nothing wrong with asking to have needs met. And in this work I will encourage you to notice where the request comes from.”

This couple’s dynamic illustrates how protective parts can get stuck in the belief that bullying, manipulating and pleading will force others to meet the needs of their exiles. When protectors encounter resistance to these tactics they become more extreme, not more thoughtful. The result is a spiral of less understanding, less listening and ever more devastating feelings of disconnection. But when we pay attention to these frustrated protectors and then reach the exiles they protect, we are inevitably taken back in time to witness traumatic relational ruptures. During the witnessing and unburdening phase of IFS, the couple learns about the unmet needs of exiled parts. The frustrations of the present: *clean up after yourself, pay attention to me right now, pay the bills*, actually represent core needs like, *I need to know I’m not alone and I can count on you*.

As Joan and Karen experienced more space inside, they slowly dropped their pattern of pursuit and attack. The quality of their conversation shifted from defensive bullying and punishment to: *let me see if I can really hear what you are saying*. As they listened they recognized that their polarized parts were voicing different concerns but were trying to get the same underlying needs met. This helped them to stop blaming and shaming, which, in turn, opened the door to making requests instead of demands. With a different understanding about the nature of their needs, couples communicate from Self on behalf of exiles rather than from a demanding manager or firefighter.

With eye contact and a calm tone, Joan said, “Karen, you know my history with my mother. Sometimes I feel overwhelmed. There’s a part of me that feels like I have no choice but to take care of you. No permission to say no, just like when I was a kid. This part feels trapped and out of control.”

Karen replied, “I want you to know it is OK with me if you say no. I would rather have you say no like this than shut me out with no explanation. I may not like it when you say no, but it’s much easier for me to deal with a straightforward no.”

Joan began to cultivate the ability to say *no* to Karen, realizing that when Karen felt disappointed it was neither the end of the world nor the end of their relationship. She also became aware of her own shame and fear about asking to have her needs met. *No needs here!* was the refrain of her protective parts until she developed a relationship with her exiles. And although I validated Karen’s longing for emotional connection, she learned more effective ways of asking for attention from Joan. She also learned to trust that she could care for herself in the moments when Joan was unavailable, a huge triumph for this couple.

CONCLUSIONS

All couples enter adult relationships with burdens from childhood. Relational rupture taps into these burdens, resulting in dysregulated interactions. Some interactions are by protectors who shame and blame internally and externally. These are met with similar protectors in the partner, which causes an escalation of painful cycles of reaction and counterreaction between protective parts. These cycles, circular and repetitive, preclude authenticity, intimacy and forgiveness.

The IFS couple therapy described in this chapter encourages individuals to make a U-turn to be curious internally. Even though the external is the therapist's initial point of contact with a couple, we invite clients to attend first to the internal attachment work with their exiles and protectors, which paves the road for external relational work. When the IFS therapist meets with a couple for the first time, she begins by inviting them into this paradigm shift, asking them to experiment with getting to know how their protective parts try, without success, to get their emotional needs met. We invite partners to explore their difficult interactions and invite them to imagine what it might feel like to have a less reactive response to their partners, to stay connected even during moments of conflict.

This is an experiential therapy that moves between fostering internal attachments and doing relational work between partners. As we help couples understand the nature of protectors and how to move from a wounded position to Self-leadership so they can unburden extreme beliefs and toxic shame, communication becomes less complicated and negotiating emotional needs for safety and connection less painful. Couples discover that a true and lasting source of transformative love inside gives them more than enough love for themselves and each other.

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